Question A: Mark Scheme & Model Answer

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Deb Orrock
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
Updated on 15 October 2024

Question A: Mark Scheme and Model Answer

The best way to improve any essay is to know how you are assessed, and what skills you are being assessed on. This page has been created to give you a sense of what examiners are looking for in a full-mark response. It contains:

- Overview
- Mark scheme
- Example task
- Model answer
- Unannotated model answer

Overview

Question A (the passage-based question) will give you a passage from the drama text printed on the exam paper, and you will be asked to analyse how the writer has achieved particular meanings or ideas. Your response must be supported with direct quotations or close reference to the passage and the rest of the play.

Mark scheme

The mark scheme for any question in Literature in English is quite broad and can seem difficult to understand. This is because there is no "correct answer" for any essay: the exam board does not provide points that need to be included in any essay; instead, examiners use the mark scheme to place an answer into a level.

Whichever question you choose in Paper 3, they are both equally weighted, and each question tests all four Assessment Objectives.

In simple terms, to achieve the highest marks (Band 8 = 23–25 marks), this means:

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

	• This means using quotations and indirect references to the play to support your views or arguments
AO2	• Sustain a critical understanding of the text by showing individuality and insight • This means showing that you understand the main ideas, settings, events, characters and other dramatic features, and that you appreciate the deeper meanings of the play
AO3	• Respond sensitively and in considerable detail to the way the writer achieves her/his effects • This means that you are able to explore how writers use language, structure and form to convey impressions and ideas
AO4	• Sustain a personal and evaluative engagement with the task and text • This means that you are able to give a personal response to the question and text, and support your response with references to the text

Help me understand

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Although there are four specific Assessment Objectives assessed in this task, it is not the case that a certain number of marks are awarded for any one objective. Instead, the examiners are looking for a well-constructed and coherent essay that seamlessly combines all of the skills covered by the Assessment Objectives.

Example task

The following task is taken from the CIE IGCSE 2017 Paper 3, and is about An Inspector Calls by JB Priestley. It is typical of the style of a Paper 3 Question A passage-based question:

Read this passage carefully, and then answer the question that follows it:

Birling: Giving us the port, Edna? That's right. [*he pushes it towards* ERIC.] You ought to like this port, Gerald. As a matter of fact, Finchley told me it's exactly the same port your father gets from him.

Gerald: Then it'll be all right. The governor prides himself on being a good judge of port. I don't pretend to know much about it. *5*

Sheila [*gaily, possessively*]: I should jolly well think not, Gerald, I'd hate you to know all about port – like one of these purple-faced old men.

Birling: Here, I'm not a purple-faced old man.

Sheila: No, not yet. But then you don't know all about port – do you?

Birling [*noticing that his wife has not taken any*]: Now then, Sybil, you must take a little tonight. Special occasion, y'know, eh? *10*

Sheila: Yes, go on, mummy. You must drink our health.

Mrs Birling [*smiling*]: Very well, then. Just a little, thank you. [*to* EDNA, *who is about to go, with tray.*] All right, Edna. I'll ring from the drawing room when we want coffee. Probably in about half an hour. *15*

Edna [*going*]: Yes, ma'am.

[EDNA *goes out. They now have all the glasses filled.* BIRLING *beams at them and clearly relaxes.*]

Birling: Well, well – this is very nice. Very nice. Good dinner too, Sybil. Tell cook from me.

Gerald [*politely*]: Absolutely first-class. *20*

Gerald	[*smiling*]: Wouldn't dream of it. In fact, I insist upon being one of the family now. I've been trying long enough, haven't I? [*as she does not reply, with more insistence*] Haven't I? You know I have.	25
Mrs Birling	[*smiling*]: Of course she does.	
Sheila	[*half serious, half playful*]: Yes – except for all last summer, when you never came near me, and I wondered what had happened to you.	30
Gerald:	And I've told you – I was awfully busy at the works all that time.	
Sheila	[*same tone as before*]: Yes, that's what *you* say.	
Mrs Birling:	Now, Sheila, don't tease him. When you're married you'll realize that men with important work to do sometimes have to spend nearly all their time and energy on their business. You'll have to get used to that, just as I had.	35
Sheila:	I don't believe I will. [*Half playful, half serious, to* GERALD.] So you be careful.	
Gerald:	Oh – I will, I will.	
	[ERIC *suddenly guffaws. His parents look at him.*]	
Sheila	[*severely*]: Now – what's the joke?	
Eric:	I don't know – really. Suddenly I felt I just had to laugh.	40
Sheila:	You're squiffy.	
Eric:	I'm not.	
Mrs Birling:	What an expression, Sheila! Really the things you girls pick up these days!	
Eric:	If you think that's the best she can do —	
Sheila:	Don't be an ass, Eric.	45
Mrs Birling:	Now stop it, you two. Arthur, what about this famous toast of yours?	
Birling:	Yes, of course. [*Clears his throat.*] Well, Gerald, I know you agreed that we should only have this quiet little family party. It's a pity Sir George and – er – Lady Croft can't be with us, but they're abroad and so it can't be helped. As I told you, they sent me a very nice cable – couldn't be nicer. I'm not sorry that we're celebrating quietly like this —	50
Mrs Birling:	Much nicer really.	
Gerald:	I agree.	
Birling:	So do I, but it makes speech-making more difficult –	
Eric	[*not too rudely*]: Well, don't do any. We'll drink their health and have done with it.	55

[*From Act 1*]

How does Priestley make this such a striking introduction to the Birling family and Gerald Croft?

Model Answer

Below you will find a full-mark model answer for this task. The commentary labelled in each section of the essay illustrates how and why it would be awarded full marks. Despite the fact it is an answer to the above question on An Inspector Calls, the commentary is relevant to any of the plays in the set text list, because it is modelling how to structure an answer incorporating the relevant Assessment Objectives.

The introduction shows a clear focus of the key word in the question – "striking" – and demonstrates thorough knowledge of the play

Priestley makes this such a striking introduction to the Birling family and Gerald Croft by beginning the play in medias res at the Birling residence. Arthur Birling leads a toast to the upcoming marriage of his daughter, Sheila, and his future son-in-law, Gerald, and the audience learns that Gerald was occupied the previous summer at "the works". It is later revealed that this is a manufacturing company owned by his father and that it is a direct competitor to Birling and Company, Arthur's business. There appears to be an undercurrent of unease, revealed via Priestley's use of forced and stunted dialogue and stage directions.

It also acknowledges the fact that it is the writer's methods that create a striking introduction to the characters

Copyright © Save My Exams. All Rights Reserved

Unannotated model answer

Priestley makes this such a striking introduction to the Birling family and Gerald Croft by beginning the play ***in medias res*** *at the Birling residence. Arthur Birling leads a toast to the upcoming marriage of his daughter, Sheila, and his future son-in-law, Gerald, and the audience learns that Gerald was occupied the previous summer at "the works". It is later revealed that this is a manufacturing company owned by his father and that it is a direct competitor to Birling and Company, Arthur's business. There appears to be an undercurrent of unease, revealed via Priestley's use of forced and stunted dialogue and stage directions.*

Firstly, Priestley employs the use of tone, as Sheila urges Gerald with "mocking aggressiveness" to "object" to being treated like one of the family. She continues, with the stage directions indicating a half-serious, half-playful tone, reproaching Gerald that he "never came near me" all the previous summer. Gerald's excuse was that he was "awfully busy at the works" and she responds in the same tone, "that's what you say". This foreshadows the revelation of Gerald's affair, and the "half serious, half playful" stage direction could reflect her naivety at the start of the play versus her maturity at

patriarchal *marriage reflects the new, emerging role of women at the time Priestley wrote the play. Traditional patriarchal attitudes towards the role of women, especially in marriage, are reinforced by Mrs Birling when she tells Sheila that she will just have to get used to her husband not being around due to "work". This is ironic and perpetuates the idea that such* ***indiscretions*** *can be overlooked as men are busy with important matters of business, and that their wives should be grateful.*

Furthermore, the introduction to the Birling family is striking in the absence of Gerald's parents at an engagement party. The use of the noble titles "Sir George" and "Lady Croft" suggest that there is a ***disparity*** *in class between the Crofts and the Birlings, and that the marriage might not be as accepted by Gerald's parents if Sheila is seen to be of lower social standing. Mr Birling's sexist attitudes are reinforced by the hesitation in remembering Lady Croft's title, as indicated by the dash and the interjection "er". It is also striking that Mr Birling struggles to remember the name of one of his future son-in-law's parents, betraying his arrogance and ignorance. This is especially striking given that Mr Birling is clearly trying to impress Gerald, as he is keen to point out that the port he is serving is "exactly the same port your father gets". Mr Birling is clearly disappointed at the Croft family's absence, as it upsets his moment in the spotlight as the father of the bride, and the opportunity to show off his wealth* ***ostentatiously****. His attitude and symbols of status, such as the port, would have immediately introduced the Birlings as unashamedly upper class to what would have been an audience having just undergone rationing and times of* ***deprivation****.*

In addition, this introduction is striking in its contrast between the new and old generations. Sheila mocks "purple-faced old men" and implies a criticism of her father's social status by reminding him that he doesn't "know all about port". Eric, Sheila's brother, does not speak until the second page of the play, and his attitude and lack of manners are striking as they contrast with his social position and the situation of an engagement party. The audience are first properly introduced to him via the stage direction in which he "suddenly ***guffaws****", interrupting the air of forced* ***congeniality****. There is the suggestion of distance between Eric and the rest of his family, as though he does not want to participate in the current* ***charade****. Eric's laugh could also imply that he knows what Gerald had actually been up to the previous summer. His final comment to Mr Birling of "Well, don't do any" implicitly criticises his speech-making and the idea of Mr Birling showing off. Mrs Birling reproaches Sheila for using the* ***colloquialism*** *"squiffy" and puts an immediate stop to any squabbling between the siblings, as though she is used to such things but does not want anything to spoil the event. Mrs Birling's attitude towards marriage, and the fact that she is clearly in charge of the domestic sphere (as she issues the instructions to the maid), place her clearly in a traditional gender role, at odds with the newer generation, embodied by Sheila's warning to Gerald to "be careful" and her accusation that Eric is drunk.*

In conclusion, Priestley creates an awkward atmosphere that is filled with tension, resentment and a sense of secrecy, which

and breeding to do so; a future son-in-law who is polite and seems to say the right things, but is not necessarily all he seems, and two siblings who are at odds with the values they have been brought up with.

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

- Create exam-aligned tests
- Tailor format & difficulty
- Quizzes or homework in minutes

Try Test Builder

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Previous Next

Course Study tools All topics

Resources

Learning Hub
Scholarship
Join
Past Papers
Solution Banks
Sitemap

Dashboard

Overview
Brand ambassador
Profile
Subscription
Settings
Log out

Company

About us
Exam Specificity
Content Quality
Promotions

Subjects

Biology
Chemistry
Physics
Maths

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.
Neither IBO nor College Board were involved in the production of, and do not endorse, the resources created by Save My Exams.